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Haskayne
School of Business

Becoming AI-Resilient: Navigating the Undergraduate Experience in an Age of Disruption

Introduction

"I am surrounded by endless opportunities, yet I feel paralyzed. I'm performing successfully without feeling successful. And I'm terrified that by the time I figure it out; the world won't need what I've learned".
- 4th year undergraduate student, University of Calgary.

This sentiment distills a national crisis. Data from the 2022 National College Health Assessment survey, confirmed a disturbing trend across Canadian campuses: a generation of students is struggling under the weight of a triple crisis; operational overwhelm, existential anxiety, and future uncertainty (ACHA, 2022; Linden et al., 2022). This is part of an international pattern; the UNESCO 2024 report on mental health in higher education, synthesizing data from over 15 countries, similarly reports that more than 60% of students experience significant anxiety or stress affecting their academic performance (UNESCO, 2024). This is not just a challenge for student support services; it is a fundamental threat to the value proposition of higher education itself.

Institutions and labour-market strategist describe a "perfect storm" (Alvarez, 2025; Goodrich, 2025; TMU, 2020, p. 5). Students are navigating the most significant personal transition of their lives, from the structured world of high school to the vast autonomy of university, all while grappling with a global mental health crisis and a job market being radically reshaped by technologies like Generative AI. As Hamoon Ekhtiari, CEO of Future Fit AI, starkly put it; "Traditionally, there was a promise. Go to school for four years, you'll have a 40-year career. That promise no longer holds" (Morrison, 2025).

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Analyses of university career-centre practices, including those published by AACSB International and University Affairs, further show that résumé and interview coaching, while still essential, are insufficient in a labour market increasingly shaped by automation and AI-mediated hiring processes. Students now require broader, continuously evolving skill development to remain competitive (Jone-Vlasceanu, 2023; Bowness, 2019).

Yet within this crisis lies a crucial insight. Research confirms that resilience is not merely a passive trait, but an active mediator against the anxiety of an uncertain future. A 2025 study in Behavioural Sciences on psychological resilience among students found that psychological resilience significantly reduces future anxiety among university students, largely by enhancing their subjective well-being, motivation and sense of agency (Dalmis et al., 2025). This inherent resilience is the untapped resource that higher education must now learn to cultivate systematically.

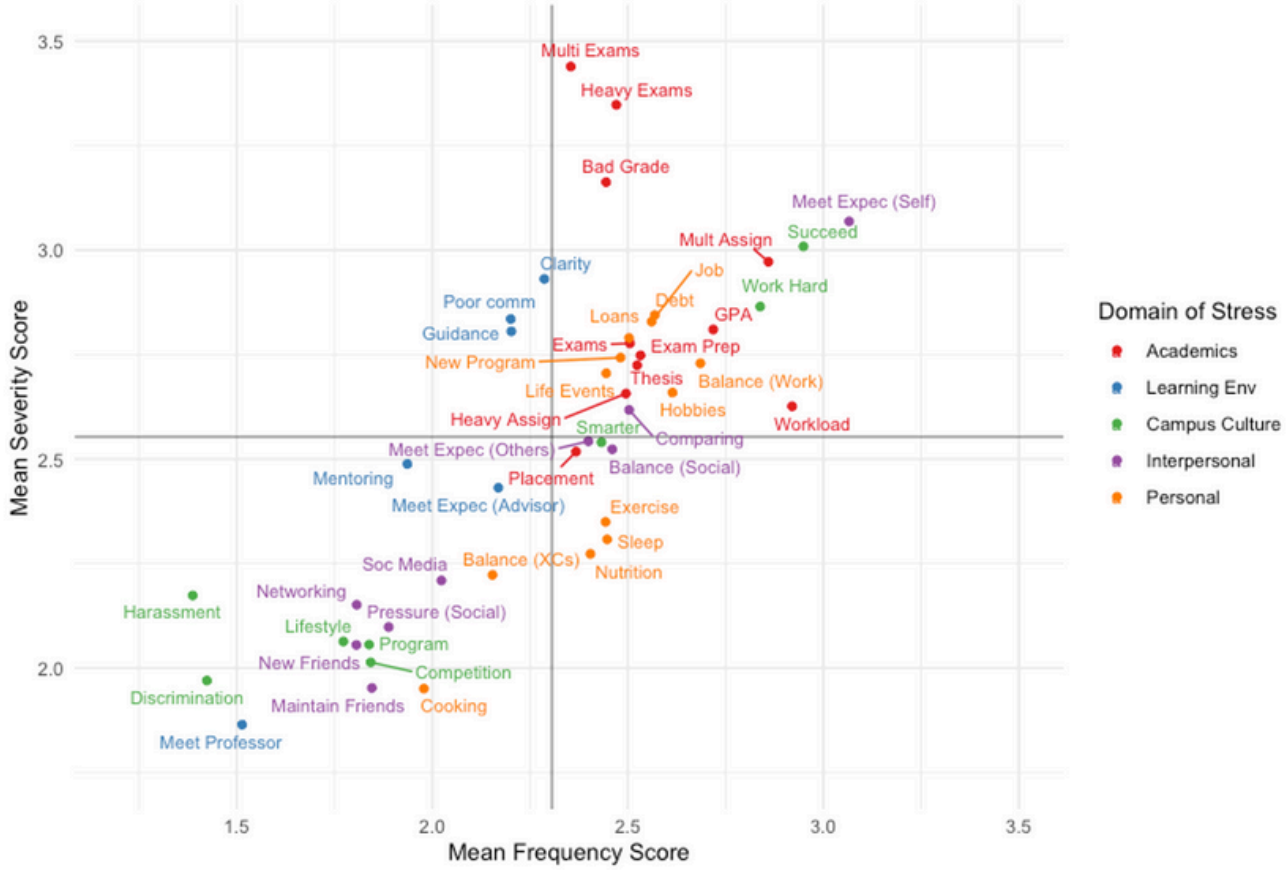
Across Canada, universities now face a critical imperative: to reimagine their role in student development. For a province like Alberta, navigating its own economic transformation, the pressure on students to 'choose correctly' is immense (Rosenberg, 2022). The goal is no longer merely to impart knowledge and a credential, but to equip students with the self-awareness, resilience, and purpose required to build meaningful lives and careers in an unpredictable future.

This experience is reflected in empirical evidence: In a large-scale study on undergraduates, 36% of all respondents agreed with the proposition that "I feel like I am studying and taking on activities without any sense of purpose or career direction", this figure rises to 67.4% when neutral/unsure responses from students were combined (Walsh & Gleeson, 2022).

A Generation on the Edge

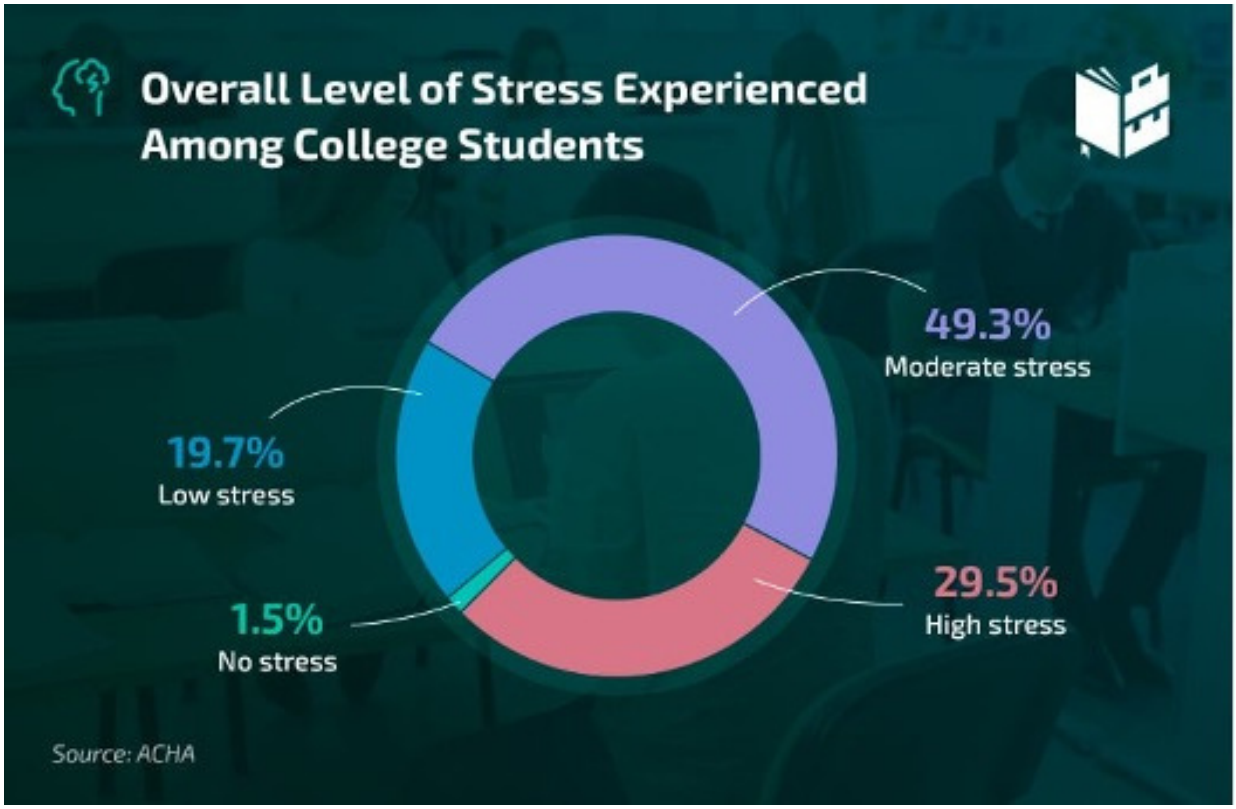
The undergraduate journey begins with a systemic shock. First-year students arrive with high expectations but are immediately confronted by a complex ecosystem they are ill-equipped to manage. In fall 2023, 1.5 million Canadian first-year students stepped onto university campuses carrying more than backpacks (Universities Canada, 2023). They carry an invisible weight: expectations, uncertainty, and algorithms that already predict their future. The leap in academic rigor and volume is profound. The shift to self-directed learning, without the daily scaffolding of high school, further leads to widespread time-management failure and academic stress. A 2022 study found that over 72% of Canadian students reported feeling frequently overwhelmed by their course load (Parker, 2022).

Students are told that their degree alone is not enough. They must build a "robust resume" with clubs, sports, and volunteer work. However, with hundreds of options across campus, choosing the "right" activities become a source of anxiety and FOMO (Fear of Missing Out), often leading to overcommitment and burnout rather than purposeful engagement (Robbins, 2022). This also leads to what researchers call "résumé-driven" participation, a mile wide and an inch deep, that fosters burnout rather than passion (Roulin & Bangerter, 2012). Additionally, they are encouraged to build new social networks from scratch, often while living away from home for the first time, which can be intensely isolating. The pressure to appear successful and happy on social platforms like LinkedIn further exacerbates feelings of inadequacy and loneliness.



Source: Linden, B. (2021). "Cross-Canada Release of the Post-Secondary Student Stressors Index (PSSI): Protocol for a Cross-Sectional, Repeated Measures Study."

This constant state of operational overwhelm leaves little room for the reflective, identity-forming work that is the true cornerstone of a university education. For many students, the absence of coordinated systems linking academic, extracurricular, and emotional development fuels uncertainty and disengagement.



Source: ACHA

Beneath these surface-level pressures lies something even more troubling. The exhaustion students feel is not only physical or academic, it is existential. Behind the late-night study sessions and résumé building lies a generation quietly asking: *What is all this for?* The system, as it stands, encourages students to “do more” without first helping them understand “why”. This growing concern highlights the need for effective support systems and interventions that can help students manage their stress and improve their overall mental health during their academic journey.

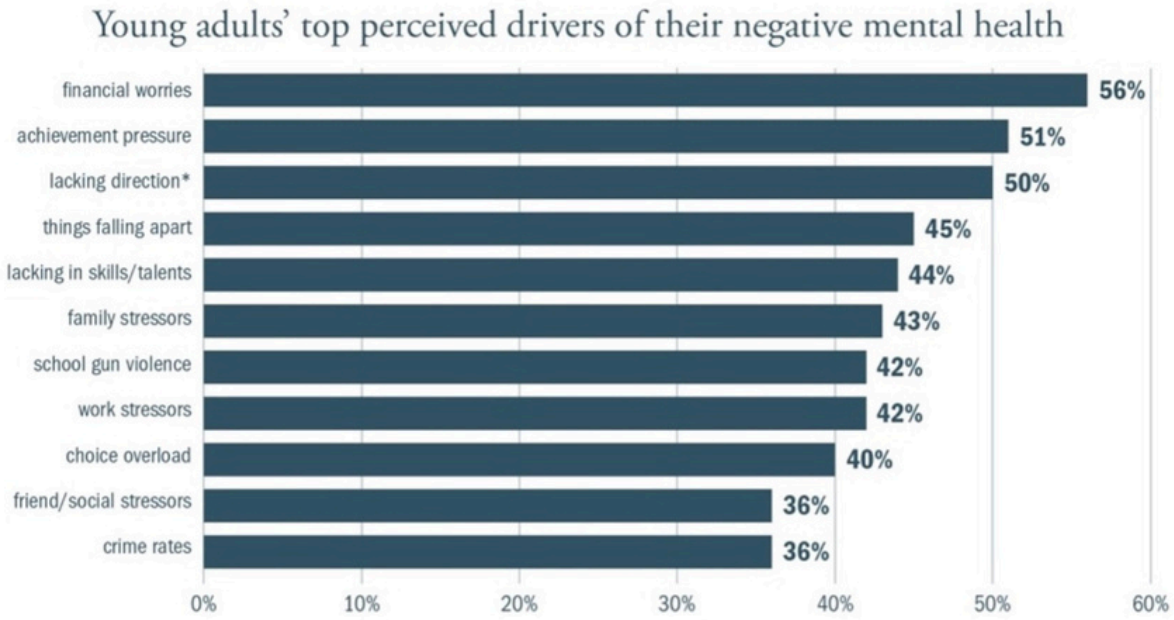
The Existential Vacuum: Achievement Without Meaning

Beneath the daily struggle to manage academics and extracurriculars lies a deeper, more philosophical crisis. The contemporary student, primarily from Generation Z (born between 1997 and 2012), is a subject of what philosopher Byung-Chul Han calls the “Achievement Society” (Ita, 2025; Han, 2015). In this paradigm, the disciplinary society of “should not” has been replaced by a society of “can,” where individuals are not oppressed by external forces but by the internalized pressure to optimize themselves to be more productive, more successful, more efficient. The modern student exists in what philosopher Charles Taylor (2007) calls a "secular age," where the grand, shared narratives (like religion or tradition) that once provided a stable horizon of meaning have receded. In their place is what philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre (1946) identified as the terrifying "condemnation to freedom," the burden of having to create one’s own essence and values from nothing.

This creates a paradox. Students are freer than ever to choose their path, yet this very freedom, without a clear narrative or sense of purpose, becomes a source of profound anxiety. For Gen Z, this plays out in a relentless pressure to curate a perfect life, to turn one's very identity into a marketable brand, leading to what researchers call "performative authenticity" (Pitti, 2025).

For many students, university itself represents "The Beyond", a mythical next stage promising not just career preparation, but a profound transformation into an independent, knowledgeable, and engaged citizen. It is sold as a rite of passage where one "finds themselves" and their place in the world. This ideal aligns with the deepest promises of the Humanistic view: that university is where you grow from a student into a citizen, equipped to contribute to a democratic society (Nussbaum, 2010; Sansom, 2023). The conflicting narratives of the university's purpose fracture this holistic vision of growth. This constant triangulation between passion, practicality, and performance turns the journey of "becoming" into a series of strategic, optimized moves. The development of the self is no longer an organic process of exploration but a curated project of human capital development, a phenomenon Han (2015) describes as the internalized pressure of the "achievement society." Students feel this dissonance acutely: This existential vacuum is filled with the characteristic pathologies of the achievement society: depression, burnout, and a pervasive sense of inadequacy (Han, 2015).

A report from Harvard and Baylor University (2025) identified that today's young adults (18-29) doubt their own character, struggle with finding a sense of purpose. Similarly, in a mental health study by the Harvard Graduate School of Education (2023), nearly 3 in 5 young adults (18-25) (58%) reported lacking "meaning or purpose" in their lives.



Source: Harvard Graduate School of Education: Making Caring Common Project (2023). On Edge: Understanding and Preventing Young Adults' Mental Health Challenges.

If the inner landscape of students' lives is marked by anxiety and uncertainty, the external world they are preparing to enter offers little reassurance. Just as students search for meaning, the ground beneath the professional world itself is shifting, and the rise of Artificial Intelligence threatens to redefine what it even means to 'succeed'.

The Looming Disruption: An AI-Driven Future

Just as students grapple with this internal crisis of purpose, the external world of work is undergoing its most significant transformation in a century. Generative AI is no longer a futuristic speculation; it is a powerful tool capable of automating cognitive tasks that were once the exclusive domain of university-educated professionals (Chui et al., 2023).

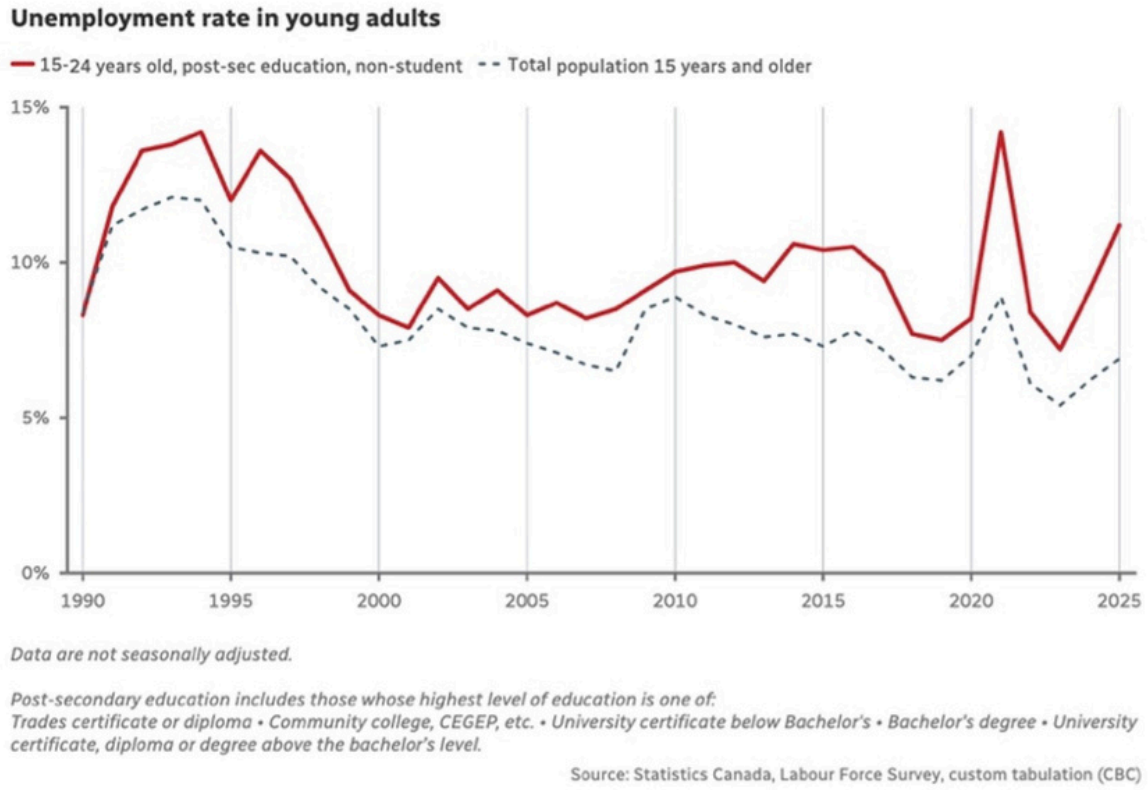
Artificial Intelligence is now a rapidly advancing technology promising to transform whole industries in the years to come. In some sectors, AI has already created a significant change in job roles. In others, the potential uses of AI and the effects of its technology in workplaces are still to be understood.

Source: Quantum Black AI by McKinsey 2025.

The data is stark. The forum Future of Jobs (2025) reveals that by 2030, 40% of employers plan to reduce their workforce where AI can automate task.

With this rising concern, recent university graduates face a more exaggerated concern, with 49% of US Gen Z job hunters believing AI has reduced the value of their college education in the job market (World Economic Forum, 2025).

According to the World Economic Forum: Jobs and the Future of Work (2025), alongside global macroeconomic trends, AI is set to further reshape the traditional career ladder, with entry-level jobs at risk. AI models can now draft reports, analyze complex data sets, create marketing content, write code, and even generate strategic briefs. This directly impacts the entry-level roles, the business analyst, the marketing coordinator, and the junior developer, who have traditionally served as the first step for graduates (McKinsey Global Institute, 2023). The formula of High GPA + Extracurriculars = Secure Job is thus becoming dangerously obsolete. This disruption is happening against a backdrop of a fundamentally new economy. As the World Economic Forum in 2016 highlighted, 65% of children entering primary school today will eventually end up in jobs that do not exist yet (World Economic Forum, 2016). This profound statistic underscores the futility of training students for a fixed set of known jobs. The Future of Jobs Report 2025 reinforces this, stating that 22% of jobs are expected to change in the next five years, through a combination of AI-driven displacement and creation of new roles (World Economic Forum, 2025).



Source: CBC Business 2025

The consequences are already materializing in the job market. There has subsequently been a global rise in the unemployment rate for recent graduates. In Canada, new graduates face a tightening sector. As of late 2025, the youth unemployment rate in British Columbia reached 16.6%, while Alberta's rate stood at 14.9%, reflecting the broader challenges new entrants face in a shifting economy. (Alberta, 2025; Career Professionals of Canada, 2025). Similarly, new graduates in the United States face an unemployment rate of 4.8% compared to the national average of 4.0% reflecting a global concern (Conte, 2025).

The convergence of these three forces, the operational overwhelm of university life, the existential search for meaning in an "achievement society," and the AI-driven disruption of the graduate workforce creates a perfect storm. Students are too busy and anxious to find their purpose, and the purpose they are implicitly training for is being systematically automated. Yet within this convergence lies a powerful opportunity. What if this moment of disruption is not an end, but a necessary catalyst? These overlapping crises, personal, philosophical, and technological, demand more than incremental change. They invite a fundamental reimagining: What if universities redesigned the first-year experience not as an academic hurdle, but as a foundational project in human resilience? The challenge is to transform anxiety into agency, uncertainty into adaptability, and pressure into purpose.

History shows that disruption breeds innovation. The internet didn't just eliminate jobs; it created entirely new industries. Today's AI transformation is a similar reflective point: a moment of great challenge and even greater potential.

You are not just studying this change; you are helping to design it. Your task is to build a new promise: an education that empowers students not just for jobs, but for meaningful, resilient, and human-centric lives. The crisis of today is your opportunity to build the resilience of tomorrow.

Your Call to Action

Navigating the transition from university to career has never been more complex. While modern technology (Gen AI) can elevate human potential, it also threatens to displace a significant portion of future graduates. In this new landscape, developing anti-fragility, clarifying personal values, and identifying one's unique human skills and superpowers will become essential tools for building a meaningful and resilient career in a VUCA world (Appendix A).

As a cross-disciplinary team of student innovators, you're working with a fictional university career centre, Ascend Career Lab, to create an Empowerment Platform that addresses the multifaceted crisis facing undergraduates. Your solution should help students move from a state of stress and uncertainty to one of self-awareness, direction, and resilience.

Your proposed solution must empower students to:

1. **Discover and Articulate Their Superpowers:** Help students identify their core strengths, values, and interests, integrating them into a coherent sense of purpose and direction.
2. **Understand the Changing World of Work:** Enable students to explore emerging career pathways and reflect on which uniquely human capabilities, such as empathy, creativity, and ethical reasoning, will be most essential in the future.
3. **Build Anti-Fragility and Future-Ready Skills:** Support students in developing personal growth plans that intentionally balance technical, creative, interpersonal, and reflective competencies.
4. **Create Continuous Growth Loops:** Encourage students to engage in cycles of feedback, reflection, and experimentation that turn uncertainty into opportunities for self-development and lifelong learning.

Deliverables

For this first round, your team must design and propose a comprehensive plan for an initiative that addresses the student resilience crisis.
Your team must propose:

- An Experiential Concept: This could take the form of a program, toolkit, curriculum, campaign, or interactive experience that guides students through the journey of discovery, reflection, and resilience-building.
- A Sustainable Engagement Model: Explain how universities, students, or community partners could adopt, fund, and sustain your initiative over time.
- A Social-Impact Lens: Demonstrate how your approach fosters inclusivity, equity, and agency for students from all backgrounds and disciplines.

Based on the applications, judges will select the finalists to come to Calgary and pitch in final round. The leaders of Ascend Career Lab are excited to partner with you. They look forward to hearing your bold, human-centric, and strategic ideas for empowering a generation to build purposeful and anti-fragile futures.

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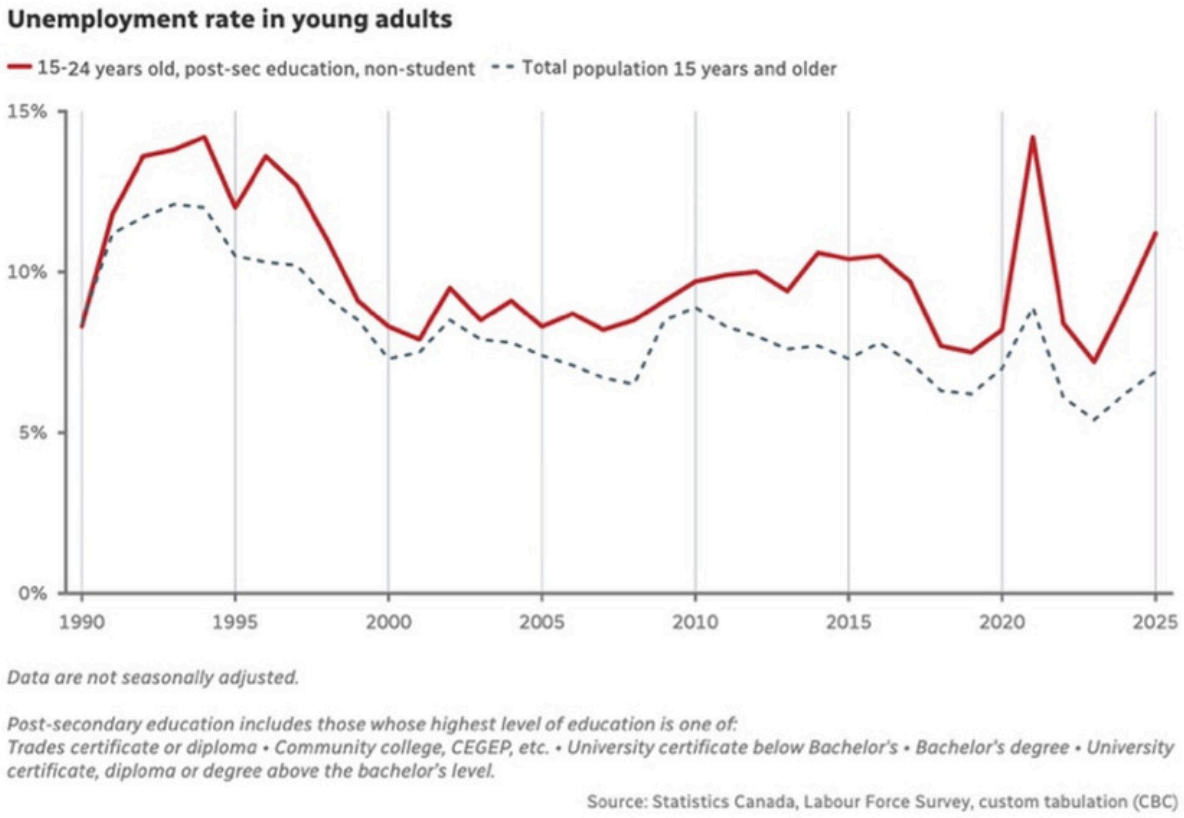
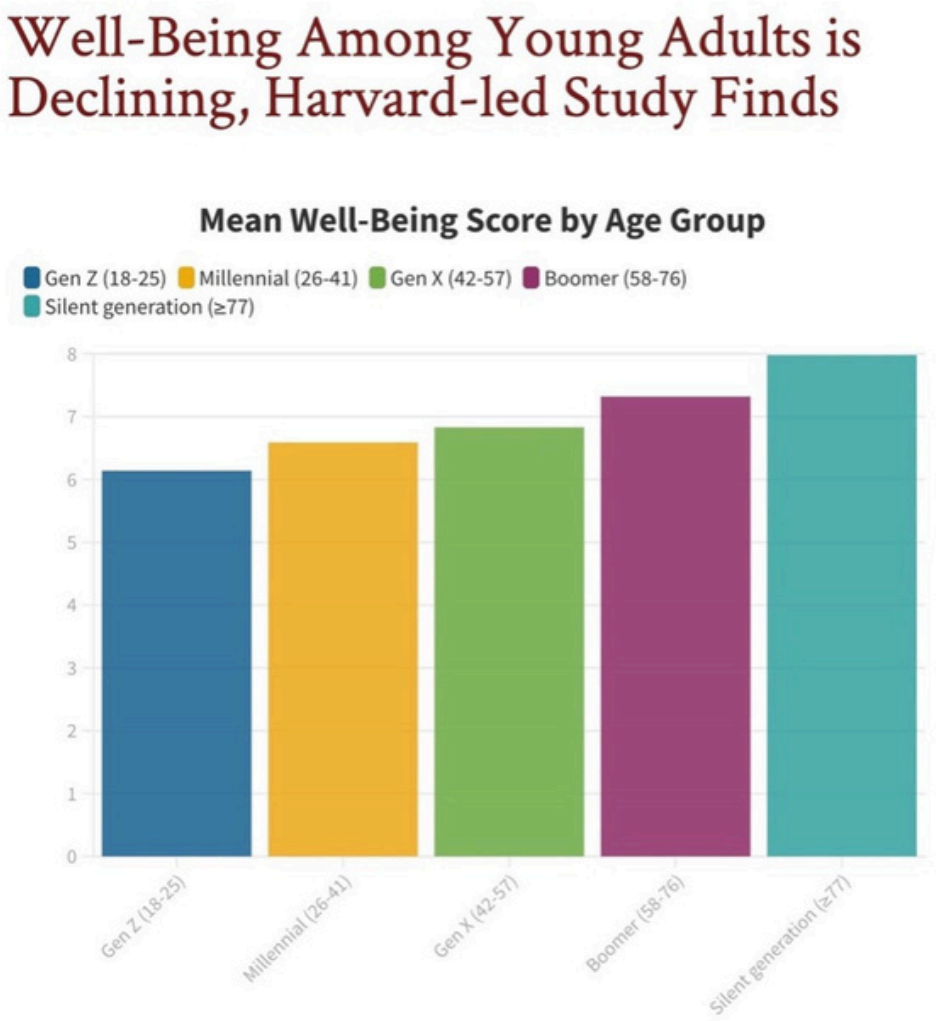
Appendix A: *What is a VUCA World?*

A VUCA world is a modern environment that is Volatile, Uncertain, Complex, and Ambiguous (VUCA), and in which students must learn, grow, and prepare for their careers (Peschl H & Peschl R).



Source: Harvard Business Review (2014). https://hbr.org/2014/01/what-vuca-really-means-for-you

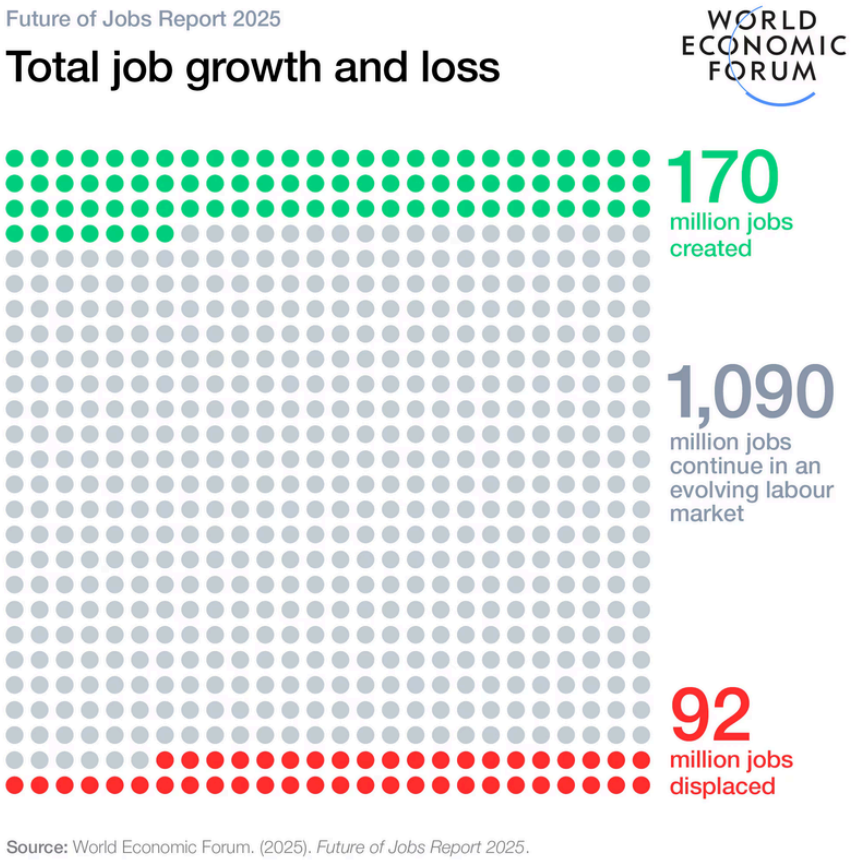
Appendix B: *Mental Health in Young Adults*



Source: SU et al. (2025). Revealing the heterogeneity of meaning in life and its relationship with creativity among university students: A latent profile analysis study.

Appendix C: *How AI Is Reshaping the Career Ladder*

The impact of Artificial Intelligence on the global labor market is a central challenge for students preparing for their careers. The following data from the World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025 illustrates the scale of transformation underway:



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